Within the initialization file, you may run any arbitrary Ruby code. For example, you can require any gem that you might want included in an irb session (for example, irbtools[1] or awesome-print[2]).

You can also set configuration values. The list of configuration variables is given in irb Configuration Options, on page 285—the values that can be used in an initialization file are the symbols (starting with a colon). You use these symbols to set values into the IRB.conf hash. For example, to make SIMPLE the default prompt mode for all your irb sessions, you could have the following in your initialization file:

```
IRB.conf[:PROMPT_MODE] = :SIMPLE
```

For a dynamic twist on configuring irb, you can set IRB.conf[:IRB_RC] to a Proc object. This proc will be invoked whenever the irb context is changed and will receive the configuration for that context as a parameter. You can use this facility to change the configuration dynamically based on the context. For example, the following .irbrc file sets the prompt so that only the main prompt shows the irb level, but continuation prompts and the result still line up:

```
IRB.conf[:IRB_RC] = lambda do |conf|
  leader = " " * conf.irb_name.length
  conf.prompt_i = "#{conf.irb_name} --> "
  conf.prompt_s = leader + ' \-" '
  conf.prompt_c = leader + ' \-+ '
  conf.return_format   = leader + " ==> %s\n\n"
  puts "Welcome!"
end
```

An irb session using this .irbrc file looks like the following:

```
irb
Welcome!
irb --> 1 + 2
    ==> 3

    \-+ 2 +
irb --> 6
    ==> 8
```

There's some dynamic behavior where the prompts change when typing that this code listing doesn't quite capture.

Extending irb

Because the things you type into irb are interpreted as Ruby code, you can effectively extend irb by defining new top-level methods. For example, you may want to time how long certain things take. You can use the measure method in the Benchmark library to do this, but it's more convenient to wrap this in a helper method.

Add the following to your .irbrc file:

```
def time(&block)
  require 'benchmark'
  result = nil
```

1. https://irb.tools
2. https://github.com/awesome-print/awesome_print